

AP HUMAN GEOGRAPHY · THE UNIVERSAL STUDY GUIDE

Targeting a 3, 4, or 5 — every concept tagged for your tier

Tier badges: [3] foundational · [4] adds for 4+ · [5] adds for 5

Targeting a 4 → study [3] AND [4] items. Targeting a 5 → study all three tiers.

PAGE 1 | MATH OF 3/4/5 · 7 UNITS · THE GEOGRAPHIC MINDSET

About this exam. AP Human Geography looks at how human activity is organized in space — populations, cultures, politics, agriculture, cities, industry.

Theoretical models are central to the exam: knowing models like the Demographic Transition, Rostow's stages, von Thünen, Christaller, and urban models earns serious points.

THE MATH OF YOUR TARGET

Target	MCQ (60 q, 50%)	FRQ (3 q, 50%)	Approx %	Tier
3 (PASS)	~28 / 60 (~47%)	~10/21 raw	~46-50%	[3] only
4	~36 / 60 (~60%)	~13/21 raw	~58-62%	[3] + [4]
5	~44 / 60 (~73%)	~17/21 raw	~70-73%	All

THE 7 UNITS — by exam weight (each ~12-17%)

#	Unit	Weight	Key topics
1	Thinking Geographically	8–10%	Maps, scale, geographic data, GIS, spatial concepts
2	Population & Migration Patterns	12–17%	DTM , age structure, migration, refugees
3	Cultural Patterns & Processes	12–17%	Languages, religions, ethnicity, diffusion
4	Political Patterns & Processes	12–17%	States vs nations , boundaries, devolution, supranational organizations
5	Agriculture & Rural Land-Use	12–17%	Agricultural revolutions , von Thünen model , sustainability
6	Cities & Urban Land-Use	12–17%	Christaller , urban models (Burgess, Hoyt, multiple-nuclei), gentrification
7	Industrial & Economic Development	12–17%	Rostow , Wallerstein world-systems , globalization, gender development

Units 2-7 are equally weighted (~12-17% each). No single unit dominates — balanced study is essential.

THE GEOGRAPHIC MINDSET — 5 spatial concepts [3]/[4]

Concept	What it captures
Location [3]	Where something is. Absolute (lat/long) vs relative (described by surroundings).
Place [3]	What a location is like. Physical + human characteristics.
Region [3]	Areas with shared characteristics. Formal (uniform — Sahara), functional (around a node — TV station broadcast area), vernacular (perceived — "the South").
Movement [3]	Migration, trade, communication, ideas across space.
Human-Environment Interaction [3]	How humans modify + adapt to their environment.

KEY INSIGHT [5] On every FRQ, name the spatial concept you're applying. "This reflects the concept of **functional region** because the area is defined by its connection to the central node..." Naming the framework earns context credit.

PAGE 2 | UNIT 1: THINKING GEOGRAPHICALLY + MASTER VOCABULARY

Maps + Map Projections [3]/[4]

Concept	What it means
Mercator projection [3]	Preserves SHAPE, distorts SIZE (esp. near poles). Greenland looks bigger than Africa. Used for navigation.
Robinson projection [3]	Compromise. Reasonable shape + size. Common general-purpose map.
Goode's homolosine [4]	Equal-area projection. "Interrupted" — splits oceans to preserve land shape.
Peters projection [4]	Equal-area. Distorts shape but accurate land sizes. Politically favored for showing equity.
Cartogram [4]	Sizes regions by data (population, GDP) rather than land area.
Choropleth map [3]	Colored regions show data values. Common for election maps, demographic data.
Isoline (contour) map [4]	Lines connect points of equal value. Topographic, weather maps.
GIS (Geographic Information System) [3]	Computer software layering spatial data for analysis.

MASTER VOCABULARY [3]/[4]

Term	Definition + tier
Scale [3]	Cartographic (map-to-real-world ratio). Of analysis (size of area studied — local, regional, national, global).
Distance decay [3]	Interaction decreases with distance. People near you affect you more than people far away.
Time-space convergence [4]	Tech (planes, internet) reduces effective distance between places.
Diffusion [3]	Spread of culture/idea/practice. Hierarchical (city → smaller places). Contagious (spreads adjacent like disease). Stimulus (idea adopted with modifications). Relocation (carried by migrants).
Site vs Situation [3]	Site = physical attributes (climate, terrain). Situation = location relative to other places.
Push vs pull factors [3]	Push = drive people away (war, famine). Pull = attract people (jobs, freedom).
Globalization [3]	Increasing interconnection of places economically, culturally, politically.
Ethnocentrism [4]	Judging other cultures by your own standards.
Cultural relativism [4]	Judging cultures by their own internal standards.
Centripetal vs centrifugal forces [4]	Centripetal = unify (shared language, religion). Centrifugal = divide (ethnic conflict).
Devolution [4]	Transfer of power from central gov to regional/local. UK to Scotland; Spain to Catalonia.
Balkanization [4]	Fragmentation into smaller hostile units. Yugoslavia in 1990s = textbook case.
Choke point [4]	Strategic narrow passage controlling trade. Strait of Hormuz, Suez Canal, Strait of Malacca.
Environmental determinism [4]	Old (debunked) theory that environment determines culture. Replaced by possibilism (environment offers possibilities, humans choose).
Cultural landscape [3]	Visible imprint of human activity on land. Buildings, fields, religious sites.

UNIT 2 | POPULATION & MIGRATION PATTERNS

Demographic Transition Model (DTM) [3]/[4]

One of the most important models in AP Human Geo. Memorize the 5 stages.

Stage	Birth rate	Death rate	Description + examples
1	High	High	Pre-industrial. Low growth. Few/no countries today.
2	High	FALLING	Sanitation/medicine reduce death; birth still high → POPULATION BOOM. Many sub-Saharan African countries.
3	Falling	Low	Urbanization + women's education → fewer children. Mexico, India, Brazil.
4	Low	Low	Stable. Most of Europe, US, Japan.
5	Below replacement	Low	Declining/aging population. Japan, Germany, Italy. Some debate whether stage 5 "exists" formally.

Population Pyramids [3]/[4]

- **Wide base** [3] = young, growing population (Stage 2 of DTM, sub-Saharan Africa).
- **Even/columnar** [3] = stable population (Stage 4).
- **Narrowing base / inverted** [3] = declining/aging population (Japan, Germany, Italy).
- **[4] Dependency ratio** = ratio of dependents (under 15 + over 64) to working-age population. High = strain on working-age.

Population Concepts [3]/[4]

Total Fertility Rate (TFR): avg # children per woman
Replacement = 2.1. Above → growing. Below → shrinking.

Crude Birth Rate (CBR) / Crude Death Rate (CDR): per 1,000 population
Natural Increase Rate (NIR) = (CBR - CDR) / 10 = % growth per year

Doubling time $\approx 70 / \text{NIR}$ (Rule of 70)

Infant Mortality Rate (IMR): deaths per 1,000 births in first year
Strong indicator of healthcare quality + development

Migration [3]/[4]

- **Push factors** [3]: war, famine, persecution, lack of jobs, environmental degradation.
- **Pull factors** [3]: jobs, freedom, family reunification, education, climate.
- **Voluntary vs forced** [3]: chosen vs coerced. Refugees, asylum seekers, slavery historically = forced.
- **Step migration** [4]: series of shorter moves toward final destination.
- **Chain migration** [4]: following family/community already established.
- **Brain drain** [4]: educated workers leaving developing for developed countries.
- **[4] Ravenstein's laws of migration**: most migrants travel short distances; people in cities migrate less than rural; women dominate short-distance, men long-distance; major migration is rural → urban; migration creates counterstreams.

Population Theories [4]/[5]

- **Malthus** [4]: food production grows arithmetically, population exponentially → famine. **Critique**: didn't anticipate Green Revolution.
- **Boserup** [5]: necessity drives agricultural innovation. Population growth FORCES food production increases.
- **Neo-Malthusians** [5]: modern adherents — concern about resource limits, climate change.

UNIT 3 | CULTURAL PATTERNS & PROCESSES

Culture Concepts [3]/[4]

- **Folk culture [3]** = small, often rural, traditional, slow-changing. Local foods, dances, dress.
- **Popular culture [3]** = large, often urban, mass-produced, fast-changing. Pop music, fast food, fashion.
- **Material vs nonmaterial culture [4]**: physical objects (clothing, food) vs ideas/beliefs (religion, language).
- **Cultural hearth [3]** = origin of cultural innovation. Mesopotamia (writing), Indus Valley (urban planning).

Diffusion Types [3]/[4]

Type	Description + example
Relocation diffusion [3]	Migrants carry culture (Spanish to Latin America).
Hierarchical diffusion [3]	Spreads from large places to smaller. Cell phones (cities first); new fashion.
Contagious diffusion [3]	Spreads adjacent like disease. Pandemics, viral memes.
Stimulus diffusion [3]	Idea adopted with modification. McDonald's veggie burgers in India (cow-respect).

Languages [3]/[4]

- **Language family [3]** = group sharing common ancestor. **Indo-European** (largest, ~46% of speakers): English, Spanish, Hindi, Russian. **Sino-Tibetan**: Mandarin, Cantonese.
- **Lingua franca [3]** = trade language. Latin (historically), English (today).
- **Pidgin / creole [4]**: pidgin = simplified mix; creole = pidgin that becomes native. Haitian Creole, Tok Pisin.
- **Dialect [3]** vs language: subjective distinction; mutual intelligibility test.
- **Language extinction [4]**: ~half of world's ~7,000 languages endangered. Globalization, English dominance, education in dominant language.

Religions [3]/[4]

Type	Examples	Key features
Universalizing [3]	Christianity, Islam, Buddhism	Seek converts; spread globally. Largest 3 universalizing religions.
Ethnic [3]	Hinduism, Judaism, Shinto, traditional African religions	Tied to specific ethnic group/place; don't actively seek converts.

- **[3] World religions by size**: Christianity (~31%), Islam (~25%), Hinduism (~15%), Buddhism (~7%), folk/traditional (~5%), Judaism (~0.2%).
- **[4] Religious conflicts**: Israel-Palestine (Jewish-Muslim); Northern Ireland (Catholic-Protestant); Sunni-Shi'a Islam; Hindu-Muslim in India.
- **[4] Sacred spaces / pilgrimages**: Mecca (Islam), Jerusalem (Judaism, Christianity, Islam), Varanasi (Hindu), Bodh Gaya (Buddhism).

Cultural Convergence vs Divergence [4]

- **Convergence (homogenization) [3]**: globalization spreads similar culture worldwide. McDonald's everywhere.
- **Divergence [4]**: counter-trend — preservation of local identity, fundamentalism, language preservation movements.

UNIT 4 | POLITICAL PATTERNS & PROCESSES

State, Nation, Nation-State [3]/[4]

Term	Definition + example
State [3]	Political entity with defined territory + permanent population + sovereignty + government. Country = state.
Nation [3]	Cultural group with shared identity (language, ethnicity, history). Doesn't require territory.
Nation-state [3]	State whose territory aligns with a single nation. Pure examples rare. Japan, Iceland approximate this.
Multinational state [4]	State containing multiple nations. Most states (US, India, UK, Russia).
Stateless nation [4]	Nation without its own state. Kurds, Palestinians, Roma.
Multistate nation [4]	Nation spread across multiple states. Koreans (N + S Korea); Arabs.

Boundaries [3]/[4]

- [3] **Physical boundary**: follows natural feature (river, mountain). Rio Grande US-Mexico.
- [3] **Cultural boundary**: separates ethnic/religious groups. Created arbitrarily by colonizers in Africa → conflict.
- [3] **Geometric boundary**: straight lines (latitude/longitude). US-Canada at 49th parallel.
- [4] **Antecedent boundary**: drawn before populations (e.g., US-Canada).
- [4] **Subsequent boundary**: drawn after populations established (most ethnic boundaries).
- [4] **Superimposed boundary**: forced by external power (colonial Africa).
- [4] **Relict boundary**: no longer functions but remains visible. Berlin Wall.

Forms of Government [3]/[4]

- **Unitary state** [3]: power concentrated in central gov. France, Japan.
- **Federal state** [3]: power divided between central + regional gov's. US, Germany, Brazil, India.
- **Confederation** [4]: weak central gov; states retain most power. Rare today.

Political Geography Concepts [4]

- **Devolution** [4]: power transferred from central to regional. UK → Scotland (1998); Spain → Catalonia.
- **Balkanization** [4]: fragmentation along ethnic lines. Yugoslavia → 7 states.
- **Centripetal forces** [4]: unify (national language, religion, sports, shared history).
- **Centrifugal forces** [4]: divide (ethnic conflict, religious differences, regional inequality).
- **Gerrymandering** [4]: manipulating district boundaries for political advantage.
- **Choke point** [4]: strategic narrow passage. Strait of Hormuz (oil), Suez Canal, Panama Canal, Strait of Malacca.

Supranational Organizations [3]/[4]

- [3] **UN** — global. Founded 1945.
- [3] **EU** — economic + political integration. Common currency (Euro), free movement.
- [4] **NATO** — military alliance (US + Europe + others).
- [4] **WTO, IMF, World Bank** — economic governance.
- [4] **ASEAN, OAS, AU, OPEC** — regional organizations.

Geopolitical Theories [4]/[5]

- [5] **Mackinder's Heartland Theory** (1904): "Who rules East Europe commands the Heartland; who rules the Heartland commands the World-Island; who rules the World-Island commands the world." Cold War rationale.
- [5] **Spykman's Rimland Theory**: control of coastal margins (Rimland) more important than Heartland. Influenced US containment policy.

UNIT 5 | AGRICULTURE & RURAL LAND-USE

Agricultural Revolutions [3]/[4]

- **1st Agricultural (Neolithic) Revolution** [3], ~10,000 BCE — domestication of plants + animals. Hearths: Fertile Crescent (wheat), East Asia (rice), Mesoamerica (corn).
- **2nd Agricultural Revolution** [4], 17-19th centuries — coincided with Industrial Revolution. Crop rotation, mechanization (seed drill), enclosure of commons.
- **3rd / Green Revolution** [3], 1940s-70s — high-yield seeds + fertilizers + pesticides + irrigation. Massive yield increases. Critic: environmental costs, dependence on inputs.
- **Genetic engineering era** [4], 1990s+ — GMOs. Bt corn, Roundup-ready soy, Golden Rice.

Types of Agriculture [3]/[4]

Type	Description + where
Subsistence: Shifting cultivation [3]	Slash-and-burn. Tropical Africa, Amazon, SE Asia. Sustainable at low density.
Subsistence: Intensive [4]	Wet rice, terraced. East/SE Asia. High labor input.
Subsistence: Pastoralism [4]	Nomadic herding. Sahel, Central Asia, Mongolia.
Commercial: Mixed crop and livestock [3]	US Corn Belt, Western Europe.
Commercial: Plantation [3]	Large estates, single cash crop, often colonial. Tropical regions: bananas, sugar, coffee, rubber.
Commercial: Mediterranean [4]	Wheat, olives, grapes. California, Mediterranean basin, Chile.
Commercial: Dairy farming [4]	Near urban markets (perishable). Wisconsin, NW Europe.
Commercial: Grain (extensive) [4]	Large-scale wheat. US/Canadian Plains, Argentina, Australia.

Von Thünen's Model (1826) [4]/[5]

Theoretical model of agricultural land use around a central market. Concentric rings based on transportation costs + product perishability.

CITY (market) at center

↓

Ring 1: DAIRY + horticulture (perishable, frequent market trips)

Ring 2: FORESTRY (heavy, expensive to ship)

Ring 3: CROPS — grains + field crops (less perishable)

Ring 4: LIVESTOCK / RANCHING (animals can walk to market)

Logic: rents highest near market; products with highest land productivity

PER UNIT distance can outbid for inner rings

KEY INSIGHT [5] **Von Thünen assumes:** isolated state, flat land, single market, equal climate, rational farmers. Real world deviates due to climate, refrigeration (allows distant dairy), highways, urban sprawl. **Be ready to apply AND critique the model.**

Agricultural Issues [3]/[4]

- **Sustainability** [3]: monoculture depletes soil; pesticide resistance; water use.
- **Food deserts** [4]: areas without fresh food access. Often urban poor neighborhoods.
- **Food insecurity** [3]: unreliable access to food. Highest in sub-Saharan Africa, South Asia.
- **GMO debate** [4]: yield vs ecological/health concerns; corporate control of seeds.
- **Organic + sustainable agriculture** [4]: lower yields but less environmental damage.

Rural Settlement Patterns [3]/[4]

- **Clustered (nucleated)** [3]: houses grouped. Common in Europe, Asia.
- **Dispersed** [3]: houses spread out. Common in US Midwest (post-Homestead Act).
- **Linear** [4]: houses along road or river.
- **[4] Cadastral patterns:** how land is surveyed. **Township-and-range** (US Midwest grid). **Long-lot** (along rivers, French Quebec). **Metes-and-bounds** (irregular, Eastern US).

UNIT 6 | CITIES & URBAN LAND-USE

Christaller's Central Place Theory [4]/[5]

Explains size + spacing of cities. Cities exist to provide goods/services to surrounding area.

Key concepts:

THRESHOLD = minimum market size needed to support a service
 RANGE = max distance people will travel for the service

Higher-order goods (rare, expensive, like specialty hospitals) require:

LARGER threshold + LONGER range
 → fewer, more widely-spaced central places

Lower-order goods (everyday, like grocery stores) require:

SMALL threshold + short range
 → many, closely-spaced places

Result: HIERARCHY of cities – many small, fewer medium, few large.

Rank-Size Rule + Primate Cities [3]/[4]

- **Rank-size rule** [3]: nth-largest city has $1/n$ the population of the largest. Common in developed countries (US, Germany).
- **Primate city** [3]: largest city is disproportionately big ($>2\times$ the second). Often in developing countries. Mexico City, Bangkok, Buenos Aires, London (UK).
- **Megacities** [3]: $>10M$ people. Tokyo, Delhi, Shanghai, São Paulo, Mexico City, Cairo, Mumbai, Beijing.

Internal Urban Structure — 3 Classic Models [4]/[5]

Model (year)	Description
Concentric Zone (Burgess, 1925) [4]	5 rings around CBD. CBD → transition zone → working class → middle class → commuter zone. Based on Chicago.
Sector Model (Hoyt, 1939) [4]	Zones in PIE-SLICE shapes radiating from CBD. Industrial along rail corridors; high-class along scenic routes.
Multiple Nuclei Model (Harris-Ullman, 1945) [4]	City has MULTIPLE centers (CBDs, malls, airports). More realistic for large modern cities.

Urban Models for Other Regions [4]/[5]

- [5] **Latin American (Griffin-Ford)**: CBD + commercial spine extending outward; affluent zones along spine; squatter settlements (favelas) on outskirts.
- [5] **Sub-Saharan African (de Blij)**: 3 CBDs (colonial, traditional, market); ethnic neighborhoods; mining towns separate.
- [5] **Southeast Asian (McGee)**: port-centered; no fixed CBD; mixed land uses; ethnic Chinese commercial cores.

Urbanization Issues [3]/[4]

- **Urban sprawl** [3]: low-density development at city edges. Car-dependent, environmentally costly.
- **Suburbanization** [3]: middle class moves to suburbs. Post-WWII US, Levitt-towns.
- **Edge cities** [4]: business districts outside historic CBD. Tysons Corner VA, Stamford CT.
- **Gentrification** [3]: wealthy newcomers move into low-income urban neighborhoods. Property values rise → displacement of poorer residents. Brooklyn, San Francisco.
- **Squatter settlements / informal housing** [3]: in developing-country cities. Favelas (Brazil), bustees (India), shantytowns. Often on hillsides + flood-prone areas.
- **Smart growth / new urbanism** [4]: mixed use, walkability, transit-oriented. Counter to sprawl.
- **Brownfields** [4]: abandoned industrial sites. Redevelopment opportunity.
- **Redlining** [4]: discriminatory denial of services (loans, insurance) by neighborhood. Targeted minority neighborhoods historically.
- **Environmental justice** [4]: poor + minority neighborhoods often near pollution sources (Cancer Alley, LA, Flint).

UNIT 7 | INDUSTRIAL & ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

Rostow's Stages of Development (1960) [4]/[5]

STAGE 1: TRADITIONAL SOCIETY

Agriculture-dominated, limited technology

STAGE 2: PRECONDITIONS FOR TAKEOFF

Education, infrastructure, savings, new ideas

STAGE 3: TAKEOFF

Manufacturing emerges in a few sectors. Rapid growth.

STAGE 4: DRIVE TO MATURITY

Industries diversify. Tech spreads. Modern economy.

STAGE 5: AGE OF MASS CONSUMPTION

Consumer society. Service economy. US, Western Europe, Japan.

CRITIQUE: Eurocentric. Assumes linear progress. Ignores historical context (colonialism).

Wallerstein's World-Systems Theory [5]

Critical theory of global inequality. Divides world into:

- **Core:** industrialized, wealthy, control of capital + tech. US, Western Europe, Japan.
- **Periphery:** poor, exploited for raw materials + cheap labor. Sub-Saharan Africa, parts of South Asia.
- **Semi-periphery:** between. Brazil, China, Mexico, India. Some industrialization, but still subordinate.

[5] **Argues:** this hierarchy is structurally maintained — periphery's poverty enables core's wealth. Different from Rostow's optimistic linear progress view.

Development Indicators [3]/[4]

Indicator	What it measures
GDP / GNI per capita [3]	Average income per person. Standard wealth measure.
HDI (Human Development Index) [3]	Composite: income + education + life expectancy. UN measure.
GII (Gender Inequality Index) [4]	Reproductive health + empowerment + labor market for women.
Literacy rate [3]	% of adult population able to read + write.
Life expectancy [3]	Average expected lifespan. Indicates healthcare access.
Internet access / cellphone subscriptions [4]	Tech development; modern infrastructure.

Industrial Location Theory [4]

- **Weber's Least Cost Theory** [4]: factories minimize 3 costs — transport, labor, agglomeration. Locate near raw materials if BULK-REDUCING (steel near iron + coal); near markets if BULK-GAINING (bottling).
- [4] **Bulk-reducing** (raw → smaller product): smelting, lumber → near material sources.
- [4] **Bulk-gaining** (assembly increases mass): cars, beverages → near markets.

Globalization + International Trade [3]/[4]

- **Outsourcing / offshoring** [3]: moving jobs to lower-cost countries. China, India, Vietnam, Mexico.
- **Comparative advantage** [4]: countries specialize in goods they produce relatively efficiently.
- **Free Trade Agreements** [3]: NAFTA → USMCA, EU customs union, ASEAN.
- **Special Economic Zones (SEZs)** [4]: areas with relaxed regulations to attract foreign investment. Shenzhen (China) the model.
- **Maquiladoras** [4]: factories along US-Mexico border, exporting to US.
- **Microfinance** [4]: small loans for entrepreneurs in developing countries. Grameen Bank (Bangladesh).
- **Fair trade movement** [4]: ensures producers get fair prices, especially coffee/cocoa farmers.

Gender + Development [4]/[5]

- **Women's empowerment** correlates with development. Educating girls reduces fertility, improves child health.
- [4] **Microfinance** + women's economic participation transforms development outcomes.
- [5] **Glass ceiling, gender wage gap, occupational segregation** persist in even developed economies.

PAGE 9 | ALL THE MODELS · the AP Human Geo signature [5]

[5] AP Human Geo's signature challenge: applying theoretical models to scenarios. This page is your master reference. On every FRQ, ask: "Which model applies?"

Model	Unit	What it explains
DTM (Demographic Transition)	Population	Birth + death rate changes through 5 stages of development
Epidemiologic Transition	Population	Causes of death shift from infectious → degenerative diseases as country develops
Ravenstein's Laws	Population	Generalizations about migration patterns
Malthus + Boserup	Population	Competing theories on food vs population growth
Diffusion (Hagerstrand)	Culture	How innovations spread spatially over time
Cultural hearths	Culture	Origins of major civilizations + religions
Heartland (Mackinder)	Political	Geopolitical importance of Eurasian heartland
Rimland (Spykman)	Political	Coastal margins more strategically important than heartland
Von Thünen	Agriculture	Concentric rings of agricultural land use around market
Boserup (revisited)	Agriculture	Necessity drives agricultural innovation
Christaller's Central Place	Cities	Hierarchy of city sizes based on threshold + range
Burgess Concentric Zone	Cities	5 concentric rings of urban land use
Hoyt Sector Model	Cities	Pie-slice sectors radiating from CBD
Harris-Ullman Multiple Nuclei	Cities	Cities have multiple centers
Latin American + African + SE Asian Models	Cities	Adapted urban models for non-Western contexts
Rostow's Stages	Industry	5-stage linear development model
Wallerstein World-Systems	Industry	Core / semi-periphery / periphery hierarchy
Weber's Least Cost	Industry	Industrial location based on minimizing transport + labor + agglomeration

KEY INSIGHT [5] FRQ trick: ALWAYS try to name a model in your answer. "This pattern reflects **von Thünen's model**, where dairy farming locates near the market due to perishability..." Even if the model doesn't perfectly fit, naming it earns context credit.

PAGE 10 | FRQ STRATEGY + 3/4/5 SCORE LADDER

AP Human Geo FRQ Structure [3]

3 FRQs total — 75 minutes. Each scored on 7-point scale. The 3 typically:

- **FRQ 1: No stimulus** — concept-based (define, explain). Often models or vocab.
- **FRQ 2: Stimulus** — interpret a map, image, or text + answer questions.
- **FRQ 3: Two stimuli** — compare 2 sources (maps, charts, photos) + analyze.

UNIVERSAL FRQ DISCIPLINE [3]/[4]/[5]

- **[3] Use specific examples** — name countries, cities, regions, not vague "some places."
- **[3] Define key terms** — "Gentrification (the displacement of low-income residents by wealthier newcomers)"
- **[4] Cite the relevant MODEL by name** — "This reflects Christaller's Central Place Theory because..."
- **[4] Provide multi-scale analysis** — local, regional, national, global as appropriate.
- **[5] Connect across units** — agriculture affects population which affects urbanization which affects political organization. The exam loves multi-unit thinking.
- **[5] Acknowledge competing theories or limitations** — "While Rostow's model suggests... Wallerstein's world-systems theory critiques this by..."

THE 3/4/5 SCORE LADDER

3-scorer writes...	4-scorer writes...	5-scorer writes...
"Cities have different parts."	"Cities have a CBD, transition zones, and residential areas, as in Burgess's concentric zone model."	"Cities exhibit distinct land-use zones. Burgess's concentric zone model (1925, Chicago) shows 5 rings — CBD, transition, working-class, middle-class, commuter. Hoyt's sector model instead shows pie-slice sectors. The multiple-nuclei model (Harris-Ullman) better fits modern cities with multiple commercial centers (edge cities). Models for the developing world (Latin American, African, Southeast Asian) reflect different colonial + cultural histories, with informal settlements often peripheral due to lack of land tenure."
"Mexico has lots of people moving to US."	"Push factors (poverty, violence) and pull factors (jobs, family) drive Mexican migration to the US."	"Mexican migration to the US reflects classic push-pull dynamics. Push factors : rural unemployment, violence (cartels), peso devaluation. Pull factors : jobs in agriculture/construction/services, family chains. Ravenstein's laws apply: most migration is short-distance + step migration; counterstreams of remittances flow south. The pattern produces a multi-state Mexican nation with significant diaspora communities. Migration both relieves Mexican unemployment and produces brain drain in some sectors."
Names a country	Names country + describes pattern	Names country + applies model + explains mechanism + acknowledges complexity

TIER-SPECIFIC TEST-DAY CHECKLISTS

For a 3 — bag ALL of these:

- ✓ MCQ: 28+ correct.
- ✓ Memorize the DTM stages + main religions + state vs nation.
- ✓ Each FRQ: define key terms; name 1 specific example.
- ✓ Identify push vs pull factors in migration scenarios.

For a 4 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 36+ correct.
- ✓ Cite at least one MODEL by name in each FRQ (DTM, von Thünen, Burgess, Rostow, etc.).
- ✓ Distinguish formal vs functional vs vernacular regions.
- ✓ Name diffusion type when describing cultural spread.

For a 5 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 44+ correct.
- ✓ FRQs: connect across multiple units (e.g., agriculture → population → urbanization).
- ✓ Cite competing theories — Rostow vs Wallerstein, Malthus vs Boserup.
- ✓ Discuss multiple scales — local, regional, national, global.
- ✓ Cite specific case studies — Mexico City primate city, Detroit deindustrialization, Shenzhen SEZ, etc.
- ✓ Acknowledge model limitations + Eurocentric biases when relevant.

THE ONE THING THAT MATTERS MOST [3][4][5]: APPLY MODELS TO EXAMPLES. AP Human Geo rewards students who can NAME a theoretical model AND apply it to a specific real-world example. Every FRQ should do this at least once. "Cities are organized in different ways" earns 0; "Burgess's concentric zone model fits 1920s industrial cities like Chicago, but modern cities like Atlanta better fit the multiple-nuclei model with edge cities at suburban interchanges" earns full credit.

If you do nothing else: master the 17 models on Page 9, and apply them to specific real-world examples on every FRQ. That's the AP Human Geo formula.

DISCLOSURE & TERMS OF USE

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